INTRODUCTION

THIS IS the first autobiography of Shahid Afridi, one of cricket's most controversial and popular all-rounders and Pakistan's biggest cricketing superstar since Imran Khan.

Afridi's story must be told. His is a tale that begins with the cricket world's most famous batting debut when, at age nineteen, not sixteen as has been believed till now, he scored a 37-ball century – the fastest the world had ever seen – against then world champions Sri Lanka. Since that incredible innings in Nairobi on 4 October 1996, Afridi's career has been quite similar to that of a suddenly successful Hollywood star who stumbles in and out of scandal, is led astray by his youth, good looks, talent and overconfidence, but is still adored for his performances.

Yet, over twenty years since his swashbuckling start, it is clear that Afridi is not a one-hit wonder. Despite inconsistent performances, he is one of the few cricketers to have earned a globally recognized nickname – Boom Boom – for his aggressive, take-no-prisoners batting that has disappointed his fans as often as it has ripped through his opponents' bowling attacks. Along the way, he has won championships, dug pitches, tampered balls, played politics, broken sledging rules and won hearts – all while reinventing himself mid-career as a brutally aggressive and freakishly quick leg-spinner who gets sponsors as quickly as he collects scalps. Today, Afridi is considered an unpredictable bad boy of the gentleman's game. But in a sport dented by corruption, he is still an honourable man.

Game Changer is the story of one of modern cricket's most controversial and high-achieving practitioners. Charted over the course of Afridi's life, from the mountains of Pakistan's unruly northwest to the mean streets of Karachi to the county grounds of southern England, this is a modern, personalized history of a global cricket legend, told as a memoir. It captures the journey of his unconventional rise, his overnight – and controversial – stardom, his weaknesses, greatest moments on the field and his future ambitions, political or otherwise. Moreover, his story is also a tale of the violent, corrupt and terror-prone Pakistan that Afridi has played in and for, and is told by one of her greatest sons.

'Of Shahid Afridi it can safely be said that cricket never has and never will see another like him,' wrote Osman Samiuddin, author of *The Unquiet Ones: A History of Pakistan Cricket* and one of the most distinct observers of cricket in South Asia, back in the mid-2000s. 'To say he is an all-rounder is to say Albert Einstein was a scientist; it tells a criminally bare story.'[1]

This book, therefore, attempts to unravel the many sides of Afridi for his fans. For the commoner on the streets of Pakistan, he is a modern Islamic demi-god, complete with his resplendent beard and open religiosity. In a London pub quiz, he is a cricket statistician's outlier, defying odds, traditions and averages. On an Australian beach, he embodies the ribald, defiant desperation of the colonized, an angry and hungry adversary who feasted on a cricket ball as